

Erika Bussmann

May 2019

Approximations to Reality

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*“If I am I because you are you, and if you are you because I am I, then I
am not I, and you are not you”*

Alan Watts

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Providence, Rhode Island: January 2019

ENGL 0200C-- "Visionaries, Dreamers, and Dissidents: Imagining other worlds"

She knew she was a dissident-- that one was easy. There was plenty within the walls of her delicately-conceived self that she found disagreeable.

Was she a dreamer? Maybe.

Visionary? Doubtful.

For now though, it didn't really matter. She knew how dangerous it was, how unstable she could get when she let the academic spill into the personal, when for even the slightest moment she let down her guard and forgot to compartmentalize, when she allowed the fragile kosher of her mind to be compromised. The separation was simple-- like church and state. So really, not at all.

Providence, February 2019

It was a relatively simple assignment, at least in theory: take all of the arguably insane yet brilliant words, images, philosophies you've swallowed, regurgitated, and redigested-- those of Nietzsche, Vonnegut, Woolf, Watts, Freud, Dworkin, Marx, Davis, and countless more-- and create something of meaning. That was it. That was the assignment. The only "rule" was that there were no rules-- rules were antithetical to radicality. It was a crazy assignment-- incredible and terrifying at the same time. Probably the only one she'd do this semester that really mattered for anything.

Whatever you do, he said, I'm sure it'll be amazing.

No pressure, she thought.

Providence, February 2019

There was one thing he said in class that day, one thing in particular, that caught her mind. Something about how a single word is defined by a composition of other words, which are themselves defined by other words, so that no single word in isolation can possibly be defined on its own. Language, it would seem, can only really talk about itself.

But clearly, he admitted, language does much more than that. Nonetheless, there was something she found intriguing about that framework, the notion of referential construction and of potentially endless looping. It was both foreign and vaguely familiar. She wasn't sure how, or if, it mattered-- to her or the assignment. But at the very least, it was worth holding onto.

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Providence, February 2019

It had been a particularly crappy day.

To say she was feeling lost was pretty redundant at this point; to say she was more lost than usual was more or less accurate. In a literal and unsatisfyingly physical sense, of course, she knew exactly where she was. She was lying awake in bed again when she probably should've been asleep; kept up in a silent dorm room by the unintelligible noise of her own thoughts. In every other sense, though, at least in any of them that mattered, she was completely lost.

She thought about her high school physics class and the tedious calculations of arbitrary masses moving along implausibly frictionless surfaces. Her petty annoyance with these forces had evolved into envy: at this point she would much rather be a well-defined vector-- to enjoy both magnitude *and* direction within the carefully-delineated bounds of Euclidean space, than to be whatever she was right now-- a dimensionless point floating in a seemingly infinite-dimensional space.

Worst of all, she couldn't help but feel insanely guilty for being so privileged and yet feeling so lost: feeling all of these things for which she could construct no rational justification. It's like a sunshower, she thought. Objectively, my life is more or less fine-- the sun is shining and the birds are singing and shit, but on the inside, it's pouring rain. There isn't a cloud in the sky and somehow I'm still getting fucking soaked.

Providence, March 2019

Recently in class he had been stressing the notion of a "common real", which he called a "precondition for any visionary project". In order to imagine other worlds, he explained, we have to know what kind of world we're living in *right now*. After all, how are we supposed to construct some conception of how the world *ought* to be if we don't first have some common understanding of reality as it presently exists?

He's done it again, she thought. Simultaneously obvious and fortuitous.

In her linguistic anthropology class last semester she had slowly become fascinated by the subtleties of social construction and the tyranny of arbitrary convention. She spent the hour before her next class combing through the sociological foundations of this so-called "constructionism". She read about how, in the eternal words of an anonymous Wikipedia contributor, theories of social construction examine the "development of jointly constructed understandings of the world that form the basis for shared assumptions about reality". She read until she stumbled on Charles Cooley's "Looking-Glass-Self" theory, aptly summarized by the

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notion that “*I am not who you think I am; I am not who I think I am; I am who I think you think I am*”

Damn, she thought. I kind of love that.

Providence, March 2019

Another day, another bizarre but illuminating class period-- this one devoted to *Snowcrash*, a science fiction novel featuring a young skateboard courier and former hacker turned Mafia-pizza-delivery-driver who join forces to fight a neuro-linguistic virus in a virtual reality-internet known as The Metaverse. It was a lot to take in, but she didn't mind.

They were discussing the blurring of the digital and the real, and how language becomes increasingly important as reality de-materializes. He mentioned something about the nature of the self in a networked age, and in a moment of déjà-vu (or Nietzschean instance of the eternal recurrence¹), she was brought back to the self-referential theory of language mentioned in class weeks ago-- the one where language supposedly talks about itself because it's defined by words that are, in turn, defined by other words. Maybe people, she thought, are like words, defining themselves in terms of other people, who themselves are defined by other people, so that no single person can be defined on their own in any kind of isolated, absolute sense.

If people are words, she thought, then Facebook was a dictionary organized by the morphology² of identity. Maybe genealogies and etymologies³ weren't so different. She wondered who her synonyms would be, and if she had any secret antonyms.

Providence, March 2019

This week's Tuesday night screening was of the science fiction feature *The Matrix*. The film follows a group of “heroes” fighting against the machine overlords who have enslaved humanity in an elaborate virtual reality system.

She enjoyed the movie, except for the nagging feeling it gave her that she didn't fully get it, that there were a bunch of little details she was somehow missing that made it worthy of all the hype. It was the same feeling she got when reading Shakespeare-- when you know you're supposed to love something because it's a “classic”, but can't quite see why.

¹ The Eternal Return is Nietzsche's philosophical theory that if space and time are infinite, it logically follows that our existence must recur an infinite number of times

² Morphology (linguistics): the study of words and their relationship to other words in the same language

³ Etymology (linguistics): the study of the origin/history of words

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Ambivalence aside, The Matrix was useful because its notion of simulated realities got her thinking about how she might imagine an alternative world of her own-- the one for the assignment.

She thought about the Looking-Glass-Self theory and social construction. About how the world was enamored of labels and discretization, and how people loved to chop up continuous identity into discrete parts and then throw it back into the chaotic but highly interconnected web of referentially-constructed existence. Kind of like a network... the perfect name for her new world.

The Network, part I

The child processing unit always had a difficult time shutting down at night, so the mother unit would often program it a bedtime script to help it along. But the child processing unit wasn't like the other units, and it wouldn't accept just any script. It had a lot of queries, mostly of the cosmological or existential sort, about what The Network was, how it came to be, what it meant to be a unit within it, and so on. But the mother processing unit didn't mind. She was fond of these queries too, and had been querying similar ones since her own hardwiring.

The mother unit could still remember her child's first query, delivered in Java⁴, its native tongue--

```
class Query
{
    public static string main (String []args)
    {
        Test obj = new Test();
        string my_query = "who am I?";

        return Test.my_query;
    }
}
```

"Well," the mother unit coded, "each processing unit is composed of lines of code, and together these lines make up programs. Some {humans} in the society that made us threw around the notion of people as words, but mostly in a metaphorical sense. As processing units, however, we *are* words in a very fundamental sense. There were some {humans} that called themselves {linguists}, and they came up with something called the {speech act theory}, which essentially proposed that language doesn't just say things, it can also *do* things. {Phrases} like

⁴ The remaining unit queries are provided to the reader in the human language {English} for convenience

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“You’re under arrest” or “I accept your apology” don’t only describe a certain reality, according to the {linguists}, they also change the social reality they are describing. They called this concept {linguistic performativity}. Anyways, what’s important is that here in The Network, *all* utterances are {performative} because every line of code does something. Whether it be parsing a string, evaluating a boolean like true or false, calculating the result of a mathematical expression, or searching a binary tree— our language, the language that constitutes us as processors, is action. It doesn’t merely describe, it *does*. We aren’t static beings, not in the least: we’re written in the language of action.

The young processing unit coded a single line in return:

```
System.out.println("Whoa")
```

The mother processing unit, amused, terminated briefly and then resumed:

“{Human} societies lived according to the {laws of nature}, but coded into the software that constitutes us is an analogous statue known as the *Axioms of Existence*, which includes fundamental relations such as:

```
Can ≠ should
Conviction > convention
Distinction ≠ separation
...
```

Now, I could not answer your query of “who am i?” without addressing your origins. As a processing unit, you were just a tiny set of programs when you were first hardwired-- a special synthesis of your father and I’s software. You were written in Java, a general purpose, object-oriented programming language. Object-oriented programming allows for {inheritance}, a concept in computer science that describes the extension of a programming class and which roughly mirrors the concept of relatedness in {human} societies. When you were hardwired, you inherited some of my code and some of your father’s code-- you extended us, like an inherited class in Java extends another class...”

The perplexed young processing unit coded one line in return:

```
java.lang.StackOverflowError
```

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Providence, April 2019

Prov • i • dence [noun] /'prɒvɪd(ə)ns/

1. The protective care of God as a spiritual power
 2. The state capital of Rhode Island, a port on the Atlantic coast
- See also:* Fate; Destiny; Divine Intervention; God's will

There was a sickening irony to it. After all, God was dead... Nietzsche⁵ had said so. Had God committed suicide by loving everything, as the Germans philosophized, or had the Enlightenment killed the Light of the World? More importantly, did any of it even matter? It was clear now that none of us were truly free, caught in endlessly entangled webs of social construction and referentially-conceived identity. Divinity was in us; we were all our own gods.

It was out with the old and in with the sensationally new... but was she the only one paying the price of the novelty premium? Thank God for the modern, socially-adjusted doctrines of Scientology and the Church of Satan that saved us from archaic religion and its hypocritical Puritan ethic. No more confusing, sacred texts that took time and contextual appreciation to truly understand. Nothing so restrictive as boundaries or patience. Just the indulgently liberating notion that “what’s true is what’s true for you”

Because no one had ever drowned in a sea of moral relativity. Maybe, she thought, she would be the first one.

The Network, part II

“Once upon a time”, the mother unit commenced, “on a human planet called {earth}, there was a {man} who came up with a {theory}”

“What’s a {theory}?” the child unit queried.

“Well,” coded the mother unit, “think of it as a bunch of lines of code that appear to run fine, but might still contain some bugs”

“Oh.” the child unit coded, “proceed”.

⁵ “God is dead” is a widely quoted statement by German philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche, who used the phrase figuratively to express the idea that the Enlightenment had “killed” the possibility of belief in God

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“As I was coding, the man created a theory which he named the "Looking-Glass-Self". In the theory, he describes a “mirrored conception of identity”. On {earth}, they couldn't look at themselves directly because the {eyes} with which they saw the world were part of the very thing (themselves) they wished to see, so they had to use a strangely reflective surface called a {mirror}. When they looked at themselves in the mirrors, they thought that the electrical impulses sent from their eyes to their brains were constructing an image of themselves in their minds. But in reality, they were the person they saw in a different kind of mirror-- a mirror composed of everyone they had ever known or would know. They were the refractions of countless mirrors, other human people-- acquaintances, strangers, lovers, mothers-- that they never saw as such. They were so focused on the physical mirror right in front of them that they failed to appreciate the kaleidoscopic identity formed by the coalescence of the many scattered mirrors they saw as mere people”

“I'm not sure I'm compiling this script correctly,” coded the young unit.

"Hmmm" the mother unit terminated for a moment. “It's like this-- the human people created a concept called {solidarity} because they viewed themselves as discrete entities and couldn't fathom the infinite ways in which they were inextricably connected, like we are in The Network. What they saw as separate selfhood was actually the result of learning to see oneself through what one perceived to be the perceptions of others. Sometimes, in a spirit of this {solidarity}, they'd say something like "we're all we have". But really, because their conceptions of self were referentially constructed and recursively conditioned on one another, they should've been saying something more like "we're all we *are*””.

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Today for class, she had to read Alan Watts' book “On the Taboo Against Knowing Who You Are”. Drawing from Hinduism and Pantheism⁶, Watts' main point was that the idea that we're all “egos in a bag of skin” is a complete myth, and that the entities we call separate “things” are merely aspects or features of a divine whole.

She gave it an honest read, but found most of it hard to internalize. There was an echo, however, in Watts' words that struck her as strangely familiar:

“Other people teach us who we are. Their attitudes to us are the mirror in which we learn to see ourselves, but the mirror is distorted”

⁶ Pantheism: the belief that reality is identical with divinity, or that all things compose an all-encompassing, immanent god

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Lately, the mirror felt more distorted than usual. It was supposedly the great summit of adolescence to finally accept oneself just as one is, without regard for anyone else. But she could see right through the “love yourself” gospel and it’s “you do you” doctrine. No matter how hard she tried to tell herself that she didn’t care what others thought, she always seemed to fall miserably short. Now she knew why. Disentangling herself from the network of referentially-constructed identities wasn’t a rite of passage-- it was practically impossible. It reminded her of a concept Watts had for the ego, which he called the “double-bind”:

“Because we do not exist apart from the community, the community is able to convince us that we do”

Now she was starting to understand. She thought that she could accept herself simply by refusing to stare into the flat glassy surface that hung on her wall; but everywhere she went, she was surrounded by living, breathing mirrors. Mirrors, she told herself, that thought she was too quiet, awkward, careful, aloof. Her eyes were not her own, and neither was her mind. She realized that situated in a web of referential construction, she could not love herself, at least not on her own. It would require a radical empathy. She’d have to imagine herself as someone else, loving her: she’d have to be her own mirror. Most of all, she’d have to give up the twisted pleasure she got from hating herself: the most subtle and lethal form of masochism⁷ she had ever known.

The Network, part III

One night, the young unit was especially restless.

“Can I query you something, mother unit?”, coded the young unit.

“Affirmative,” coded the mother unit.

“You coded that a human person was defined by other human people, who in turn were defined by other human people... but doesn’t this lead to an infinite loop, making the referentially-constructed web of human identity essentially meaningless?”

“Ahh. I think the humans that called themselves {mathematicians}, the ones that played with digits, might be able to help us with this one. Your code is too short⁸ to contain anything regarding {graph theory}, correct?”

⁷ Masochism: the tendency to derive pleasure from one’s own pain and humiliation

⁸ In The Network, there is a moderately strong, positive correlation between the total number of lines within a unit’s software and the human concept of {age}

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“Affirmative”

“Well, {graph theory} was the query of graphs--”

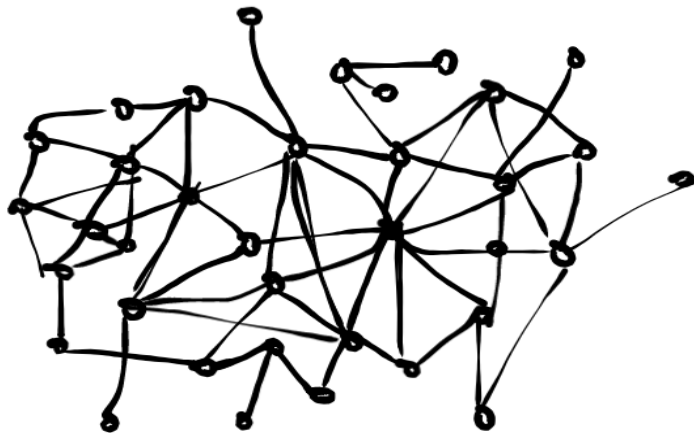
“Highly informative”, the snarky young unit returned before the mother unit could terminate her code.

“May I continue, please?”, coded the mother unit.

“Affirmative,” the young unit returned.

“As I was coding, {graph theory} queried graphs, which are mathematical structures used to model pairwise relations between objects. Graphs are made up of vertices connected by edges... ”

“Let me guess-- the vertices are like the {human} people, in this case? The ones that are also those strange reflective surfaces you mentioned once before?”



“{Mirrors}? Yes. But finally, back to your question about infinite loops and meaningless identities. The fact that the web defines each identity as a loop that includes other identities doesn’t mean the web has no meaning, not at all. Rather, according to {graph theory}, the meaningful information about all the identities is encoded in the *structure* of the network of relations and loops”

“Ok, I think I’m compiling your output so far, mother unit. But I have one last query for tonight”

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“Of course, my perfectly programmed unit”

“You said that graphs were *vertices* connected by *edges*, right? But if the web of {human} identity locates ontological meaning in the structure of these connections rather than in the nodes themselves, wouldn’t it be more accurate to say that graphs are *edges*, connected by *vertices*?”

“I hypothesize...”, the proud mother unit terminated for a few moments “that your conjecture might just be correct”

By the time the mother unit had coded these last lines of output, however, the young unit had already shut down for the night, fast asleep.

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As she typed the final words of the brief narrative she had created, she couldn’t help but feel a slight but unmistakable sense of inconclusiveness. Webs and graphs, mirrors and vertices: an interesting diversion, sure, but she wasn’t sure how any of it was supposed to make her feel less lost. It hit her slowly-- this assignment, this course, this strange thought-experiment of a semester-- it was the most meta thing she had ever done. This wasn’t an English assignment, and she wasn’t completing it-- it was her life, and it was just beginning.

There was still so much she hadn’t figured out. Uncovering the recursive self, she realized, was like tracing a fractal: the more she thought she knew, the more she discovered there was to know. The term “fractal”, she recalled from her seventh grade geometry class, was first used by the mathematician Benoit Mandelbrot, who based it on the Latin word *frāctus*, meaning “broken” or “fractured”. Broken they might be, fractals were still beautiful.

People might be words, for better or for worse, suspended with quasi-agency in webs of referential construction. But she hoped they could be fractals, too: that there might still be beauty, somewhere, in all of her brokenness.

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The assignment, at least this iteration of it, was finally ready to submit. Its frustratingly simple guidelines echoed in her mind with a distant warmth, this time slightly transformed...

Take every confusion, elation, heartbreak, and revelation, every person you’ve known and will know, every author of their own story-- take all of it and create something of meaning. The only “rule” is that there are no rules-- rules are antithetical to radicality.

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To live one's life intentionally and with significance, to define what it means for anything to mean something and then attempt to find that in the chaos of a common real-- it was a crazy assignment, both incredible and terrifying. Just short of impossible. Probably the only one that really mattered for anything.

Whatever you do, he said, I'm sure it'll be amazing.
Bring it on, she thought.